CHINEMELU OKAFOR

cokafor@g.harvard.edu
chinemeluokafor.com

HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Education

Harvard Government Department — Cambridge, MA
Ph.D. Government, *Graduate Prize Fellow* — May 2028

Harvard Government Department — Cambridge, MA
A.M. Government — May 2025

Princeton University — Princeton, NJ
Emerging Scholars in Politics Program — August 2021

The George Washington University — Washington, DC
M.A. Applied Economics, *Dean's Award* — May 2018

University of Michigan — Ann Arbor, MI
B.A. Economics & International Studies — May 2015

Primary Fields Political economy, comparative politics, public economics
Secondary Fields Economic development, cultural economics, narrative economics

References

Melani Cammett (Chair)
Harvard University
mcammett@g.harvard.edu

Nathan Nunn
University of British Columbia
nathan.nunn@ubc.ca

Awa Ambra Seck
Harvard Business School
aseck@hbs.edu

Pia Raffler
Harvard University
praffler@gov.harvard.edu

Mashail Malik
Harvard University
mashailmalik@fas.harvard.edu

Belinda Archibong
Johns Hopkins University
barchib2@jh.edu

Working Papers

Protest Matters: The Effects of Protests on Economic Redistribution (with Belinda Archibong, Evans Osabuohien and Tom Moerenhout). Reject and Resubmit, *Review of Economics and Statistics* [NBER working paper, 2026].

Abstract: Can citizen-led protests lead to meaningful economic redistribution? We study the effects of protests on fiscal redistribution using evidence from Nigeria. We digitized twenty-six years of public finance data from 1988 to 2016 to examine the effects of protests on intergovernmental transfers. We find that protests increase transfers to protesting regions, but only in areas that are politically aligned with disbursing governments. Two natural experiments- the large-scale 2012 Occupy Nigeria protests and 2015 presidential election- validate these results. Protesters also face increased police violence, particularly in non-aligned regions. The results show that protests can influence fiscal redistribution.

The Origins of Women's Economic and Political Participation in Africa. [Draft available upon request].

Abstract: Women's economic participation is not uniform across the world. Africa continues to stand out in its singular ability to engage women in the economy both in terms of levels of female labor force participation and heterogeneity. While the dominant explanation for women's (dis) empowerment elsewhere points to the historical introduction of the plough, Africa had nearly no exposure to plough technologies and instead was primarily characterized by hoe-farming. Still, African ethnic groups exhibited substantial historical variation in the extent to which women played a dominant role in agriculture. What, then, explains the origins of women's economic participation across Africa? I argue that whether contemporary African women participate in the labor force is in part driven by differences in historical norms developed from ethnic groups' gendered farming practices which were themselves driven by tasks necessary for crop cultivation. In the absence of plough machinery, societies considered reaping men's tasks and considered sowing and weeding women's tasks. This gendered division of tasks effectively gave rise to distinctly men's and women's crops across the continent. To test this, I link pre-colonial ethnic group data on whether women worked more (or only) in agriculture to gendered folklore motifs data, present-day female labor force participation data and data on political participation across the continent. I instrument for women's historical role in agriculture using exogenous grid cell-level crop suitability data and the historical crop classification of men's and women's crops established by social anthropologist Hermann Baumann. I find empirical evidence that women's historical economic participation in the economy, amongst societies more suitable for women's crops, predicts women's participation in the economy and household decision-making autonomy. The results also suggest that ethnic groups in areas more suitable for women's crops exhibit fewer gender motifs depicting female domesticity, female submission, and male violence in their historical folklore.

Works in Progress

What's in a Name? Toponyms, Origin Myths and Women's Economic Empowerment in Africa.
Do "female-named" communities reflect a social history that has led to more economic empowerment for women in some areas today?

Cultural Festivals and the Persistence of Gender Norms Concerning Women's Work: Evidence from an Encouragement Design in Nigeria.
Do cultural festivals, specifically annual harvest festivals celebrating "women's crops," generate the common knowledge necessary for progressive gender norms to be advocated for?

The Effects of Women-Led Protests on Gender Gaps in Political Participation (with Belinda Archibong, Nonso Obikili and Oluseye Ajuwon).
Can protests lead to meaningful changes in political participation, particularly among marginalized groups like women?

Fellowships & Grants

Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, *Dissertation Writing Fellowship*	August 2026
Econometric Society Africa Summer School	July 2026
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Mid-dissertation Grant	April 2026
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Pre-dissertation Grant *(x2)*	April 2026
John C. Hansen & Katherine Vogelheim, Research Grant	January 2026
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, GSA Grant *(x2)*	October 2026
Harvard Center for African Studies, Travel Grant	May 2025
Association for Comparative Economic Studies Summer School (*fully funded)*	July 2025
Harvard Government Department, Women and Politics Research Grant	April 2025
Harvard Jens Aubrey Westengard Scholarship	May 2024
Forbes 30 Under 30 N. America: Education - Founder, Research in Color Foundation	November 2022
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Summer Language Grant	April 2022
Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences *Graduate Prize Fellowship*	August 2021
Harvard Department of Government *Karl Deutsch Fellowship*	August 2021
American Political Science Association *Diversity Fellowship*	December 2020
Best Overall Performance in the Applied Economics Master's Program, *Dean's Award*	May 2018

Teaching Experience

Harvard Business School — Cambridge, MA
Course Assistant for Hakeem Belo-Osagie — Fall 2026
Immersive Field Course: South Africa

Harvard Business School — Cambridge, MA
Course Assistant for Hakeem Belo-Osagie — Spring 2026, 2025
Business & Entrepreneurship in Africa

Harvard Department of Government — Cambridge, MA
Honors Thesis Advisor; Advisee awarded — Spring 2026
Philippe Wamba Prize for the best senior thesis in
African Studies at Harvard College

Harvard Department of Government — Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Matt Reichert — Spring 2026
Research Practice in Qualitative Methods

Harvard Department of Economics — Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Stan Veuger — Fall 2025, 2024
Public Economics: Designing Govt. Policy

Harvard Department of Government — Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Prof. Michael Hiscox — Spring 2025
Evaluating the Impact of Public Policies

Presentations & Conferences

2026 American Political Science Association Annual Meeting; PhD Excellence Initiative Conference, Stanford University
2025 Harvard Center for African Studies Contested Realities Workshop
2024 African History Through the Lens of Economics, London Business School; J-PAL Research Staff Training, Massachusetts Institute of Technology
2022 J-PAL Research Staff Training, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

Academic Affiliations

Harvard Center for International Development, PhD Affiliate — August 2025 - Present
Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Graduate Student Associate — August 2024 - Present
Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Graduate Affiliate — October 2022 - Present
LBS Wheeler Institute's African Research Councillors Programme, Collaborator — May 2022 - Present

Academic Service

Reviewer for: *The Annual Review of Economics*

Harvard Concentration Advisor and Non-Resident Tutor — August 2024 - Present
Harvard Resident Tutor, *Winthrop House* — August 2021 - 2023
Specialties: French language, public service, first-gen low-income, economics and government

The Research in Color Foundation — May 2019 - Present
Founder and President
Since 2019, 95 scholars have benefited from financial assistance and eight months of direct mentorship with economists and quantitative social scientists through my 501(c)(3) non-profit the Research in Color Foundation®. Of those 95, *34 alumni* have started a PhD in economics or an economics-adjacent field. Research in Color has raised over $160,000 in scholarship funding for mentees.

Selected Experience

White House Council of Economic Advisers *(took leave from PhD)* — Washington, DC
Staff Economist — August 2023 – 2024
Area(s) of focus: African Growth & Opportunity Act; De Minimis; China Shock; Section 301
Selected Projects: Economic Report of the President, Chapter 5, *Council of Economic Advisers* 2024

Emerging Scholars in Political Science Program — Princeton, NJ
Predoctoral Research Specialist — August 2019 – August 2021
Area(s) of focus: Racial and ethnic politics; Historical applied microeconomics
Selected Projects: White Americans' Reactions to Racial Disparities in COVID-19, *American Political Science Review* 2022

Empirical Studies of Conflict Project — Princeton, NJ
Research Specialist II — September 2018 – August 2019
Area(s) of focus: Natural resource extraction and conflict in Sub-Saharan Africa
Selected Projects: Mining Competition and Violent Conflict in Africa, *Journal of Politics* 2025

The International Finance Corporation Washington, DC
Research Assistant February – October 2018
Area(s) of focus: Private-sector firm development in Sub-Saharan Africa
Selected Projects: Making It Big: Why Developing Countries Need More Large Firms,*IFC* 2020; Creating Impact: The Promise of Impact Investing, *IFC* 2019; Beyond Capital: Monitoring Development Outcomes of Multinational Enterprises, *World Bank* 2018.

The World Bank Washington, DC
Consultant June – August 2017
Area(s) of focus: Major challenges to firm operations in post-conflict settings
Selected Projects: Surviving Firms of the Syrian Arab Republic, *World Bank* 2018.

The United Nations Joint Inspections Unit Geneva, CH
Research Intern August 2015 – January 2016
Area(s) of focus: System-wide monitoring and evaluation of United Nations agencies

The Royal African Society London, UK
Research Intern May – July 2014
Area(s) of focus: African Affairs; African literature, writing and art
Selected Projects: 50 Books by African Women That Everyone Should Read

Technical Skills RStudio, STATA, LaTeX, ArcGIS, Qualtrics, JavaScript, Microsoft Office Suite

Field Work Nigeria: July 2025; June 2025; January 2025; December 2024

Languages English (Fluent), French (Upper-intermediate proficiency), Igbo (Passive proficiency)

Citizenship United States; Nigeria